

Wegovy (semaglutide) — Patient Information

Purpose of Treatment

Wegovy is used to promote weight loss by decreasing appetite, increasing the feeling of fullness (satiety), and slowing stomach emptying.

Nature of Treatment and Cost

Treatment is generally chronic (long-term) in order to maintain the weight-related benefits.

The average cost without insurance is approximately \$450 per month.

Generic versions have been available since the summer of 2026, which may reduce costs.

Common (Expected) Side Effects

These effects are generally transient and occur mainly at the beginning of treatment or when the dose is increased.

Digestive:

- Nausea: 16–20%
- Diarrhea: 10%
- Vomiting: 5–9%
- Abdominal pain: 6–11%
- Constipation: 3–6%
- Bloating: 2–3%
- Gas: 1–2%
- Reflux: 2%
- Dyspepsia (indigestion): 3–4%

Other:

- Increased lipase: 22–34% (usually of no consequence)
- Hypoglycemia: 2–4% (mainly if you are on diabetes treatment)
- Fatigue / dizziness: 0–1%
- Injection site reaction: 0–1%

Tips to Improve Tolerance

- Eat slowly and in small amounts
- Avoid fatty meals at the beginning of treatment
- Follow the gradual dose escalation schedule
- Maintain good hydration

Rare but Important Side Effects

Pancreatitis: a rare but potentially serious complication

Pancreatitis is a rare side effect of Wegovy, but it is important to know that, in some cases, it can lead to serious complications.

- In approximately 80% of cases, pancreatitis is mild and resolves without lasting effects.
- However, in 10 to 20% of cases, it can become more severe.

Notable complications:

- Severe infection (sepsis): approximately 5 to 10% of cases — requires hospitalization
- Risk of death: approximately 2 to 5% overall, but up to 20 to 30% in severe forms

Gallstones (~2%)

Associated with rapid weight loss. Pain under the ribs on the right side after meals.

Retinopathy (in patients with diabetes)

May occur if blood sugar improves rapidly. Watch for visual symptoms.

Thyroid cancer (very rare, not demonstrated in humans)

A signal observed in animal studies. Avoid if you have a personal or family history of medullary thyroid carcinoma or MEN2 syndrome.

When to Seek Prompt Medical Attention

- Severe, persistent abdominal pain
- Significant vomiting or dehydration
- Visual disturbances
- A lump in the neck or difficulty swallowing

Recommended Follow-Up

Regular medical follow-up is necessary to adjust the dose, monitor tolerance, and evaluate the benefits of treatment.